

Shearwaters: 10% of the world population?

BirdLife Malta's figure, tested against regulator and published estimates

THE CLAIM

“...around 1,600 – 1,800 pairs, constituting approximately 10% of the global population.”

BirdLife Malta, LIFE Arcipelagu Garnija project page (undated)

On the Yelkouan shearwater (Garnija), classed as Vulnerable.

The world total is poorly known: estimates span 11,000 to 55,000 pairs.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

*An important share;
“about 10%” rounds up 6–8%.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

1,795–2,635

Pairs in Malta, ERA plan

The regulator's newer count overlaps and exceeds the page's 1,600–1,800.

21–36k

Pairs worldwide

The figure most often quoted; a 2008 review gave 11,355–54,524 pairs.

4–9%

Share with the page's count

1,600–1,800 of 21,000–36,000 pairs: central 6%.

5–13%

Share with ERA's count

10% is inside this range; central 7.8%.

>50%

One colony, Tavolara

Sardinia's Tavolara holds over half the world population (Pezzo et al. 2021).

FAIR TO SAY

Malta holds an internationally important share of a vulnerable seabird. “Roughly 5–10%” would be safer.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ BirdLife Malta: year and source of the count.

☐ BirdLife Malta: the global figure behind 10%.

☐ ERA: method for 1,795–2,635 pairs.

☐ ERA: latest Article 12 figures.